

Sandbags for Home Runoff

Fill, fold, and stage bags before the rain. Turn over for placement at a house or driveway.

△ CAUTION — PREVENT HARM

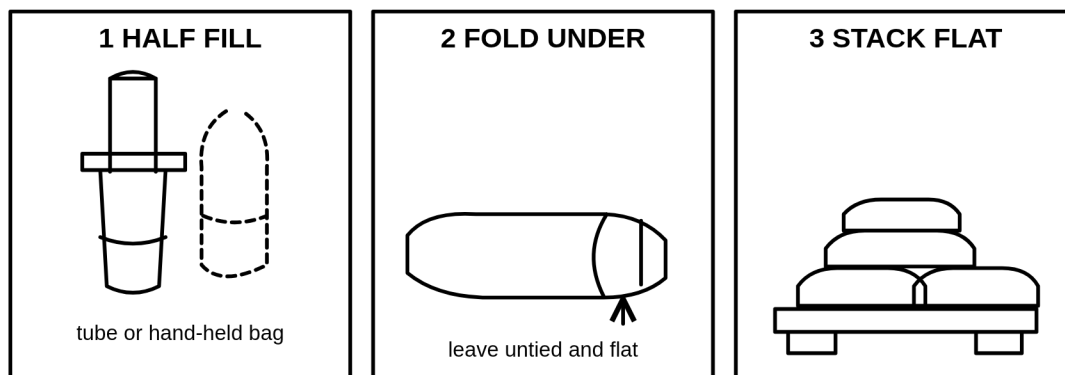
Work on level, dry ground. Wear gloves and sturdy shoes; use eye protection when sand is dusty. A filled bag may weigh 35–40 lb—use a partner or lighter bags if needed.

1. FILL BAGS SO THEY FLATTEN

- 1 Use clean sand if available. Hold the bag open with its rim rolled outward, or slide it over a stable filling tube.
- 2 Shovel in sand until the bag is about **half full**; leave the upper half empty so the fill can spread flat. Do not pack it full.
- 3 If using tubes, fill each to the same level and lift the rack straight up. Check each bag's weight and fill; tube dimensions do not guarantee the right amount.

2. FOLD THE OPEN END

Flatten the sand toward the closed end. Fold the empty top underneath the filled portion. For a temporary barrier, leave the bag untied so it molds against the next bag.



Fill → fold → pallet. Keep bags flat and the pallet load centered.
Original Fire Watch diagram, based on the sources below.

3. STACK ON A PALLET

- 1 Set a sound pallet on firm, level ground where it will stay dry and accessible.
- 2 Lay bags flat, snug, and entirely inside the pallet edges. Turn the next layer across the first to interlock the stack.
- 3 Keep the pile low and stable; do not exceed the pallet or moving equipment's rated load. Secure it before moving; keep people clear of a shifting stack.

SOURCES

U.S. Army Corps of Engineers, *Flood Fight Handbook* (2022), §2.1–2.3:
www.mvp.usace.army.mil/Portals/57/MVP%20Flood%20Fight%20Handbook%202022.pdf. RiverOakRanch, "Filling Sandbags the Easy Way, With Sandbag Tubes" (2010): www.instructables.com/Filling-Sandbags-the-Easy-way-with-Sandbag-Tubes/. Accessed 2026-09-24.

Sandbags for Home Runoff — continued

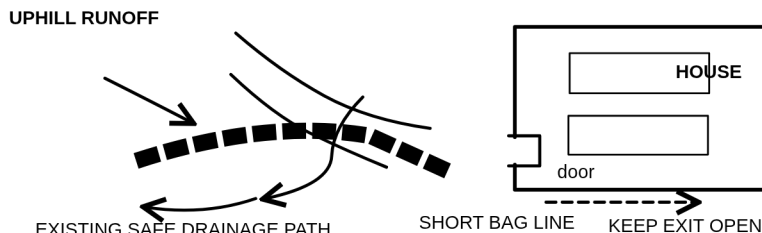
Use a short, low row to steer shallow runoff or pooling away from a vulnerable opening.

× DANGER — STOP NOW

Leave the area if water is moving fast, rising around you, or cutting off your exit. Do not enter flowing water or build beside an unstable slope or wall.

1. PICK THE ROUTE

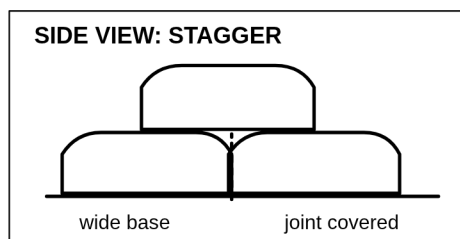
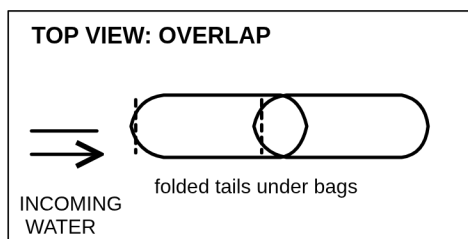
Find where water arrives and a safe outlet. Set bags on firm ground **uphill of the opening**. Lead water to an existing drain path on your property—never toward a neighbor, road, or another doorway. Keep drains and your exit open; watch for pooling behind the line.



Plan view. Trace the water's entire path before placing a bag.
Original Fire Watch diagram, adapted to a hillside home.

2. LAY A LOW, TIGHT LINE

- 1 Clear loose debris and fill low spots first. Keep the line short, low, and away from a building wall.
- 2 Lay bags flat, **folded end underneath and toward incoming water**. Lap the filled part over the previous bag's empty end; press them together.
- 3 For a second layer, cover joints below. Widen the base as height increases; avoid a tall, narrow wall.



Top and side views. Overlap the tails; stagger joints and widen the base.
Original Fire Watch diagram, after USACE §2.3.

Recheck from safe ground: check for water around the ends, through gaps, or pooling behind the line. Bags redirect shallow water but do not form a watertight seal. Leave if conditions worsen.

SOURCES

USACE, *Flood Fight Handbook* (2022), §2.2–2.3:

www.mvp.usace.army.mil/Portals/57/MVP%20Flood%20Fight%20Handbook%202022.pdf.